coast and traders had been kept safe from the firangis as long as Malik Ayaz, a Christian from Russia, kept careful vigil over its pewter seas. From the island of Diu he had built a chain-link barrier across the shallow waters to prevent access to firangi ships and it was said that ‘during the government of the Malik, the Firangi was unable to enter the Gujarat ports’. But Malik Ayaz had died and the Portuguese appetite for the pepper which had made the fortunes of the Portuguese king, would no longer be denied. They seized Diu in 1535 and imposed the cartaz, which was a pass issued by the Portuguese against which they promised protection for Indian trade ships from plunder at the hands of other Portuguese pirates. This was a move stoutly resisted by all the traders in the Indian Ocean, as it was considered humiliating and implied the payment of debilitating taxes, but the Portuguese were unstoppable. At the time of Akbar’s first encounters with the Portuguese, they had already established a lucrative trade in African slaves. Between 1575 and 1595, tens of thousands of Africans were sent from West Africa to Brazil, to lead lives of abomination and degradation.

In faraway Naples a different kind of firangi, Rudolf Acquaviva, was continuing on his exalted and stricken path which was to lead him, however improbably, to the opulent Mughal court. He had been admitted to the Jesuit novitiate in Rome where he loved to work in the kitchens and in the infirmary. While he practised austerities in his bleak cell, he offered his sacrifices in the hope that he would be sent on a mission to Hindustan where lost souls were crying out for salvation.

As soon as Akbar arrived in Cambay ‘the merchants of Rum, Syria, Persia and Turan’ came to pay their respects to the Padshah. Akbar may have sampled some of the Gujarati food which was peculiar to the region. Historian Aparna Kapadia has studied the list of foods mentioned in a fifteenth-century text of the region called the *Varnak Samucay*. She writes of a truly bewildering number of courses presented during a meal which was usually served on a large platter reminiscent of the present-day thali. The text suggested starting a meal with fresh fruits, dry fruits, and nuts, followed by a variety of laddus, jalebis, and fried snacks such as dahi vada. This would be followed by laapsi, a liquid dessert made from wheat, almost in the way of cleansing the palate, before an avalanche of main courses—rice dishes, dals, ghees, vegetables, more fried snacks, and breads. Finally, it was suggested that the sated and presumably incapacitated diner be